

Restate your research problem/question :

What are the emotional challenges of young people growing up in conflict zones, and how do those experiences carry over to their adult lives? Does it inform their identity or change them?

Research

(Interviews, define project limitations)

Interviews

Before the writing process begins storytelling material must be collected. For this project, the best source of information will be the interviews with people who have experienced growing up in zones of conflict. Interviews provide personal stories and allow the filmmaker to get the information needed through their preplanned questions. During this period, I will look for stories or events that inspire my script. I hope to interview at least 3-5 people until I feel like I have a cohesive story I can tell, I expect to finish this stage within a week. Most of these interviews will be with family members or family friends. I will make sure to ask for consent for including things in my project. By the end of this phase, I should have compiled enough information to begin to write a story and further understand the complex topic of living in conflict.

Define project limitations

Making sure this project is possible within the timeframe given is extremely important. I will be the only person working on this film so research must be done to understand the project's technical limitations. This will mean creating limitations to how many characters I can write into the script (due to asset development), how many environments can be modeled, the length of the film, etc. This task must be done before scriptwriting begins so I know my limitations. At the end of this phase, I should fully understand the workload that is expected in the production of this film and know what limitations I need to consider while writing the story.

Creation Stage 1

(story development, storyboarding, mood board, concept art)

Story Development

During this phase, I will use my takeaways from the interviews to create a plot. I will write a script-style paper describing the entire story, environments, and characters. I will then show this paper to the interviewees for feedback and then finalize my story. The finalized script should be a moving story that addresses the anti-war theme while incorporating personal stories. I should be able to understand the entire story and feel confident creating it in animation.

Storyboarding

Using my script I will begin to visualize the story using storyboards. Storyboards allow me to understand the composition of a scene and understand how the character moves through it. Storyboards are drawings that show a scene's evolution over time. Storyboards make the animation process much easier by making certain creative decisions in advance. Storyboards can be rough and low quality as long as they communicate the scene. I should have the entire

film storyboarded before moving on. This does not mean that every few frames need a panel but that from start to finish I have visualised the key movements of the characters and the environments they inhabit. Understanding every scene, I should now be able to identify the length of the film.

Mood Board

A mood board can be used for many purposes during the planning stage. It is used to compile images that inspire, because of this I will make multiple mood boards. Possible categories for mood boards include lighting, character design, environment design, etc. The goal of this stage is to strengthen my understanding of the visual composition of this film and what stylistic choices I make for the assets. After creating the mood boards I should be able to identify what stylistic choices I will be making.

Concept Art

The storyboarding process is meant to begin visualizing the film, concept art is part two of creating the composition. Instead of covering the entire film in rough detail, this phase allows me to choose a few key moments in the film to draw in detail. The scenes that will be chosen will be among the most important scenes in the film. These scenes that are meant to impact the viewer must be planned beforehand. Each drawing should create a compelling composition that adds to the written story. These drawings will then be used as a reference during the entire production process from environment design to lighting to color-grading.

Creation Stage 2

(music choices, asset development, animation, compositing)

Music Choices

Good music makes a scene ten times more powerful. Soundtracks set the tone and communicate the filmmaker's intent. During this stage, I will be looking for music to fit with my film. I will be using copyright-free tracks or if need be research crediting copyrighted music. I should have multiple songs chosen before I move to production. The music helps inform the animation so it is crucial to have music chosen in advance.

Asset Development

This phase is many different phases compiled into one. The asset development phase includes the creation of the environments, characters, rigs, and textures. Both the environments and characters will be defined by the choices made in *Creation Stage 1*. Rigs are the skeletal system we use to animate a 3d model. Texturing is the process of coloring a 3d model, texturing will need to be done for almost everything in any given scene. Asset development will take significant time, possibly more than the animation itself. This phase is all about setting the scene while animation is about movement in the scene. Asset development and animation are sometimes done in parallel because sometimes the scene composition will change while animating and a new model will be needed or a new environment. In my case, I will create key assets like the characters and environment in advance and any 'prop' objects could be made

parallel to animation. It is also important to note that I will not be modeling everything, I will download certain models from the internet and credit the creators in the credits of the film.

Animation

Animation consists of animating the characters, animating camera movements, and adding any FX to the scene. Character animation is extremely important because it's how the character conveys their emotion to the audience. Facial animation will most likely take the bulk amount of time because of its importance in immersing the viewer in the film. At the end of this phase, the film should be rendered out and everything outside of compositing should be finalized.

Compositing

Color can completely change a film, think of key examples like Schindler's List, where the movie is devoid of color but when we do see color it is used as a storytelling technique. Color-grading is the process of manipulating the colors of a render, it can be used to set a tone, enhance certain imagery, highlight a character, and more. In *Creation Stage 1* I use mood boards to identify what stylistic choices I will make, this includes color-grading. In this stage, I implement those decisions. Another key part of compositing is editing, this means compiling my rendered scenes together and making sure they transition nicely, it also means adding sound effects and adding my music choices. Compositing marks the end of the production phase, which means all finishing touches like credits, extra FX, and greenscreen work are all done here. Compositing is only finished when the film is finished.

Testing

Focus Group

This film means to impact people and convey its theme against conflict, the only way to know if it impacts people is to ask. During this final phase, the film will be shown to a focus group and their feedback will be collected. If their feedback is positive then the film has accomplished one of its goals. If the group has critique it will be implemented if possible.